

Upanishads:

1. The Upanishads {Sanskrit: उपनिषद्} are late Vedic and post-Vedic Sanskrit texts that "document the transition from the archaic ritualism of the Veda into new religious ideas and institutions“.
2. They are the most recent addition to the Vedas, the oldest scriptures, and deal with meditation, philosophy, consciousness, and ontological knowledge. Earlier parts of the Vedas dealt with mantras, benedictions, rituals, ceremonies, and sacrifices.
3. Around 108 Upanishads are known, of which the first dozen or so are the oldest and most important and are referred to as the principal or main (mukhya) Upanishads.
4. The ‘**mukhya**’ Upanishads are found mostly in the concluding part of the Brahmanas and Aranyakas and were, for centuries, memorized by each generation and passed down orally.

Rigveda – Speaks of Universal Conscious - (i) Aitareya

Yajur Veda – Speaks of Manifestation – Forms & Shapes – (ii)Taittiriya, (iii) Brhadaranyaka, (iv) Isa, (v)Katha

Samaveda - Speaks of Characteristics of Different forms – (vi)Chandogya, (vii) Kena

Atharva Veda – speaks of Application – uses – (viii)Prasna, (ix) Mundaka, (x) Mandukya

Vedantas:

- The 'mukhya' Upanishads, along with the Bhagavad Gita and the Brahmasutra, are interpreted in divergent ways in the several later schools of Vedanta.
- The central concern of all Upanishads is to discover the relations between ritual, cosmic realities (including gods), and the human body/person, postulating **Ātman** and **Brahman** as the "summit of the hierarchically arranged and interconnected universe."
- According to Advaita Vedanta, there is no difference.
- According to Vishishtadvaita the jīvātman is a part of Brahman, and hence is similar, but not identical.
- According to Dvaita, all individual souls (jīvātmans) and matter are eternal and mutually separate entities.

Table 3.1 provides a comparative picture of the three schools of Vedānta, summarising the salient aspects of the schools on several elements of philosophical thinking.

TABLE 3.1 A Comparison of the Salient Features of the Three Schools of Vedānta

No.	Criterion	Advaita	Viśiṣṭādvaita	Dvaita
1	Basic reference for establishing the tenets	Upaniṣads, Bhagavadgītā, Brahmasūtra	Upaniṣads, Bhagavadgītā, Brahmasūtra	Upaniṣads, Bhagavadgītā, Brahmasūtra
2	Concept of Īśvara	One, attribute-less (Nirguṇa-brahman)	One, personal God (Saguṇa-brahman) – Viṣṇu or Nārāyana, Independent, Ultimate	One, personal God (Saguṇa-brahman) – Viṣṇu or Hari, Independent, Ultimate
3	Concept of Universe (Jagat)	Not real, mere illusory experience, made of Prakṛti and Guṇas	Real, made of Prakṛti and Guṇas	Real, made of Prakṛti and Guṇas
4	Jīva-Jagat-Īśvara relation	All are one and the same – Brahman	All are part and parcel of Īśvara, Jīva and Jagat depend on Īśvara	All are uniquely different, Jīva and Jagat depend on Īśvara
5	Valid means of knowledge (Pramāṇas)	Perception, inference, comparison, verbal testimony, presumption, non-apprehension	Perception, inference, verbal testimony	Perception, inference, verbal testimony
6	Liberation	Experience oneness with Brahman	Attaining the feet of the Lord	Knowledge of the greatness of Īśvara
7	Path to liberation	Jñāna-yoga, Karma-yoga as a pre-requisite	Bhakti and Prapatti, Bhakti-yoga, Karma-yoga and Jñāna-yoga as pre-requisites	Bhakti-yoga, Grace of Īśvara